

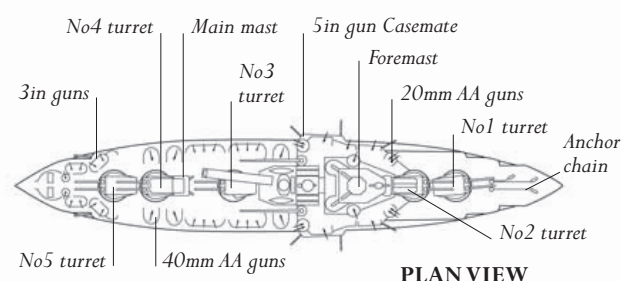
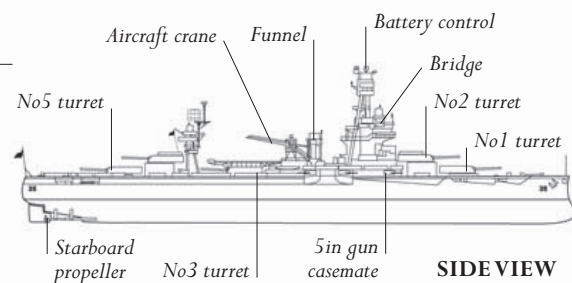
SUPER-DREADNOUGHT BATTLESHIP

USS TEXAS

The *Texas* was the product of the naval arms race that preceded World War I. A “super-dreadnought”, it earned five battlestars during a long service career that spanned more than 30 years.

With a main armament of ten 14in guns, the *Texas* entered service in 1914 as the world’s most powerful warship. In some respects it was behind the times, especially in using coal-fired reciprocating engines rather than oil-fired steam turbines. An extensive modernization in 1927 installed oil-fired boilers, improved the ship’s armour, and upgraded its fire-control systems. Later changes included the addition of many anti-aircraft guns and fire-control and air-defence radars.

By World War II, the *Texas* was too slow to keep up with more modern capital ships in combat, but its guns still packed a powerful punch. The *Texas* escorted convoys in the Atlantic before the USA entered the war. Later, the ship was prominent in a shore bombardment role, providing fire support for landings in North Africa, Normandy (see pp.340–41), Iwo Jima, and Okinawa. The *Texas* suffered only one combat fatality, when its conning tower was hit by a shell from a German shore battery in 1944.



▲ USS TEXAS

A New-York-class battleship, the *Texas* was built at a cost of around \$6 million. It was 175m (574ft) long, displaced 27,000 tons, and had a top speed of 21 knots.

AROUND THE DECK



▲ REAR VIEW OF FOREMAST

Below the battery control are other areas that need a high, clear line of sight such as the bridge and lookout platforms.

► SHIP'S BELL

Used to mark the time of day and regulate duty watches, this large brass bell on the deck was engraved with the ship's name.



▲ ANCHOR CAPSTANS

In front of the 14in bow guns, two large electric capstans rotated to raise or lower the anchors. At the stern there are other capstans, which were used for towing.



▲ BATTERY CONTROL

Observers in the battery control relayed readings for range, speed, and bearing to the plotting room below deck which, in turn, sent instructions to the gunners.

► SOLE SURVIVOR

Decommissioned in 1946, the USS *Texas* is now a museum ship at San Jacinto, Texas. It is the last surviving dreadnought-era battleship.

